

Chapter 8: The Woman from His Past

The air outside the restaurant felt colder than it should have.

Jenny stood a few steps behind Austin.

The woman across the street didn't move.

She simply smiled.

Like she had been waiting for this exact moment.

Austin's posture changed immediately.

Not obvious.

But Jenny noticed.

His shoulders tightened.

His expression became controlled.

Careful.

Like he was putting on armor.

Jenny leaned slightly closer.

"Is she really your ex-wife?"

Austin didn't look at her.

"Yes."

Simple.

Flat.

No emotion.

But that was the problem.

It sounded too controlled.

The woman stepped forward.

Elegant heels clicked against the pavement.

She crossed the street slowly.

Unbothered by traffic.

Unbothered by anything.

When she reached them, she stopped in front of Austin.

Her eyes flicked briefly to Jenny.

Then back to him.

"So this is where you've been hiding," she said.

Her voice was calm.

Too calm.

Austin didn't respond immediately.

Then—

"I'm not hiding."

The woman smiled faintly.

"No? It looks like it."

Jenny shifted slightly.

She suddenly felt like she was standing in the middle of something she didn't understand.

Something old.

Something unfinished.

The woman turned slightly toward Jenny.

"And you are?"

Jenny opened her mouth.

But Austin answered first.

"No one important."

The words landed sharply.

Jenny froze.

The woman raised an eyebrow.

"Oh?"

Jenny looked at Austin.

He didn't meet her eyes.

Not even for a second.

Something uncomfortable tightened in her chest.

The woman studied Jenny properly now.

Like assessing something.

Not rude.

Not kind.

Just analytical.

Then she nodded slightly.

"I see."

Jenny didn't like that tone.

Not at all.

Austin finally spoke again.

"Why are you here, Isabella?"

So that was her name.

Isabella.

The ex-wife.

Isabella tilted her head slightly.

"I was in the area."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only one you're getting."

A pause.

Then she looked at the restaurant behind them.

"The Golden Dragon still exists," she said lightly.

"It does," Austin replied.

"And you still prefer places like this?"

Jenny frowned.

Places like this?

She opened her mouth—

But Austin cut in.

"Say what you came to say."

Isabella smiled again.

"I heard you've been... visiting regularly."

Silence.

Jenny's eyes moved between them.

Regularly?

So it wasn't just coincidence.

It wasn't just food.

Isabella's gaze drifted to Jenny again.

"Interesting choice."

Jenny stiffened.

"I'm standing right here."

Isabella looked almost amused.

"Yes, you are."

Austin's voice turned sharper.

"Don't involve her."

That sentence surprised Jenny.

It shouldn't have.

But it did.

Isabella studied Austin for a long moment.

Then sighed softly.

"I'm not here to fight."

"That's new," Austin said.

A flicker of irritation crossed Isabella's face.

But she controlled it quickly.

"I'm here because I needed to confirm something."

Jenny frowned.

"Confirm what?"

Isabella ignored her and looked directly at Austin.

"You're slipping."

The words hit differently.

Even Jenny felt it.

Austin didn't respond.

Isabella continued.

"You used to be careful. Focused. Untouchable."

A pause.

"And now you're spending time in a restaurant every day."

Jenny's heart skipped slightly.

That sounded wrong.

Too personal.

Too pointed.

Austin's voice dropped.

"This conversation is over."

Isabella ignored him.

Instead, she looked at Jenny again.

"This isn't your world," she said softly.

Jenny felt something flare inside her.

"I figured that out already."

Isabella's smile returned.

"But you're standing in the middle of it anyway."

Silence again.

Heavy this time.

Austin stepped slightly forward.

"Leave."

Isabella held his gaze for a moment longer.

Then she exhaled.

"As you wish."

But before she turned away, she added quietly—

"I wonder how long she'll last."

Jenny's stomach tightened.

Austin's jaw clenched.

"Enough."

Isabella finally stepped back.

But her eyes lingered on Jenny one last time.

Not hostile.

Not kind.

Curious.

Then she turned and walked away.

Her heels faded into the distance.

Leaving silence behind her.

Jenny didn't move.

Neither did Austin.

For a long moment, neither spoke.

Then Jenny finally asked,

"Why did she say that?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

He looked away.

Toward the street.

"Because she knows me."

"That's not what I asked."

A pause.

Then—

"Because she thinks she still does."

Jenny studied his face.

There was something there now.

Not arrogance.

Not control.

Something heavier.

History.

Pain, maybe.

She lowered her voice slightly.

"Does she?"

Austin finally looked at her.

For the first time since Isabella arrived.

"No."

A simple answer.

But it didn't feel simple.

Jenny folded her arms.

"So what was that?"

"Closure."

"That didn't look like closure."

"It is for her."

"And for you?"

Austin didn't answer.

That silence said more than anything else.

A cool wind passed between them.

Jenny glanced back toward the restaurant.

Then back at him.

"You should go inside," she said.

Austin looked at her.

"You're telling me what to do now?"

"Yes."

A faint pause.

Then, unexpectedly—

"I'll listen."

That surprised her again.

He turned slightly toward the restaurant.

But before walking away, he said quietly,

"She's not important anymore."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because something about the way he said it...

Made her feel like that wasn't entirely true.

And worse...

Made her realize she didn't know what part of his life she had stepped into.

Only that she was already inside it.

Far deeper than she intended.